EASY WEEKNIGHT DINNER RECIPES FOR TIRED NIGHTS (PLUS THE CHEAT CODES WE WISH WE'D KNOWN SOONER) WHAT'S FOR EATS | PRINTABLE DINNER GUIDE

Easy Weeknight Dinner Recipes for Tired Nights (Plus the Cheat Codes We Wish We'd Known Sooner)

Skip to the recipes

New recipes are dropping

Next recipe update in:

00

days

00

hrs

00

min

00

sec

Three free dinners, from "barely cooking" to "set it and forget it"

Each one is sorted by how much energy you have left. Pick your fighter. Want more like these? Browse our
easy dinner ideas for nights with no energy
.

Level 1: Microwave sweet potato with black beans

5 min of effort

About 10 min total

Serves 2 to 3

Dishes: 1 plate

You'll need

2 large sweet potatoes

1 can (15 oz) black beans, drained and rinsed

1 cup shredded cheese

1/2 cup salsa

Optional: sour cream or avocado

Here’s how

Scrub the potatoes under water and poke each one all over with a fork. Those holes let steam escape so nothing explodes.

Put them on a microwave-safe plate. Microwave 6 to 8 minutes, flipping halfway, until a knife slides in with no fight.

While they rest, warm the beans in a bowl for 1 minute.

Split each potato down the middle. Pile on beans, cheese and salsa, and let the heat melt the cheese.

Good to know:
Potatoes keep cooking for a minute after the microwave stops, so let them sit before you slice. No fresh ones? Microwave frozen cubed sweet potato in a bowl instead.

Level 2: Sheet-pan sausage and broccoli

15 min of effort

About 40 min total

Serves 4

Dishes: 0 (foil-lined pan)

You’ll need

1 package (12 oz) fully cooked sausage, sliced into coins

4 cups broccoli florets, fresh or frozen

1 lb baby potatoes, halved

2 tbsp oil

1 tsp garlic powder, plus salt and pepper

Here’s how

Heat the oven to 425 F and line a sheet pan with foil. Foil is the whole "zero dishes" trick.

Toss the potatoes with half the oil and a pinch of salt. Spread them cut side down and roast 10 minutes. They need a head start because they’re the slowpokes.

Add the broccoli and sausage, drizzle with the rest of the oil, sprinkle on the garlic powder and pepper, and toss right on the pan.

Roast 15 to 20 more minutes, until the potatoes are fork-tender and the edges look

browned.

Good to know:
Cut the potatoes small and spread everything in a single layer. Crowded pans steam instead of roast, and steamed broccoli is a sad broccoli. More pan meals in our easy sheet-pan dinners guide
.

Level 3: Slow cooker salsa chicken

5 min of effort

3 to 7 hours, hands off

Serves 6

Dishes: 1 (0 with a liner)

You'll need

2 lb boneless, skinless chicken breasts

1 jar (16 oz) salsa

1 packet taco seasoning

1 can (15 oz) black beans, drained

For serving: tortillas, rice, shredded cheese

Here's how

Spray the slow cooker or add a liner. Lay the chicken in the bottom (thawed, please).

Sprinkle the taco seasoning over the top, then pour on the salsa and beans.

Cover and cook on LOW 6 to 7 hours, or HIGH 3 to 4 hours, until the chicken reaches 165 F in the thickest part. Keep the lid closed. Every peek adds about 20 minutes.

Shred it with two forks right in the pot and stir it back into the sauce.

Serve in tortillas, over rice, on a baked potato, or straight from a spoon at the counter. We won't tell.

Good to know:
Leftovers keep 3 to 4 days in the fridge and freeze well for up to 3 months. Reheat to 165 F. For safe temperatures on other meats, see the USDA safe minimum cooking temperature chart
. More hands-off ideas:
slow cooker dinners for busy families
.

The 5:47 p.m. Rescue Kit

Quick, friendly detour. The problem was never the recipes. It’s the deciding. By 5:47 your brain has clocked out, so we built a kit that asks one question: how tired are you? Then it hands you dinner. A growing library, with new recipes added every month.

Pick by energy level
Houseplant, Upright or Future Me. See the dish count before you commit.

Plan the week
One click fills seven dinners around how worn out each day will be.

Auto grocery list
Built from your week and sorted by store section.

Printable fridge sheet
So nobody has to ask you what’s for dinner ever again.

Shortcut pantry
Tick what you own and see what you can start right now.

Favorites and tracker
Save the winners and count what you’ve made.

Opens in your browser. No app to install. Your picks save on your device.

Get the Rescue Kit

Cheap dinners that don’t taste cheap

Budget cooking isn’t about eating sadly. It’s about knowing where your money goes. Here are two dinners built from pantry staples, plus the little habits that make groceries last. For a deeper dive, read our guide to cheap family dinners with the cost per serving, or see the USDA MyPlate healthy-eating-on-a-budget tips.

Egg fried rice (better than takeout and done in 15)

15 min

Serves 4

Dishes: 1 skillet

You’ll need

3 cups cooked rice, ideally cold, or 2 microwave rice pouches

4 eggs, beaten

1 cup frozen peas and carrots

3 tbsp soy sauce

2 tbsp oil

Optional: sliced scallions

Here’s how

Heat the oil in a large skillet over medium-high heat. Add the frozen vegetables and cook 2 to 3 minutes, stirring.

Push the vegetables to one side. Pour the eggs into the empty space and scramble until fully set, with no runny bits.

Add the rice and break up any clumps with your spoon. Cook 3 to 4 minutes, until hot and just starting to crisp.

Splash in the soy sauce, toss everything together and top with scallions.

Good to know:
Cold rice fries better than fresh, because fresh rice turns gummy. Leftover rice from last night is the secret ingredient.

Pantry tomato pasta with white beans and spinach

20 min

Serves 4

Dishes: 1 pot and a colander

You’ll need

12 oz pasta

1 jar (24 oz) marinara sauce

1 can (15 oz) white beans, drained and rinsed

2 cups baby spinach, or 1 cup thawed frozen spinach

Parmesan for the top

Here’s how

Boil the pasta in salted water according to the package. Scoop out 1/2 cup of the pasta water before you drain.

Return the empty pot to the stove over medium-low heat. Add the marinara, beans, spinach and a splash of pasta water.

Simmer 3 to 4 minutes, until the spinach wilts and the beans are hot.

Stir in the pasta, toss to coat and top with parmesan.

Good to know:

Beans add protein and make one jar of sauce feed more people. Frozen spinach is cheaper than fresh and works just as well here.

Three stretch tricks

Buy the big bag, then portion it.
A large bag of rice or pasta costs less per serving than small boxes.

Add beans, lentils or eggs.
They stretch meat dishes and make meatless nights feel like real dinner.

Freeze the second half.
Soups, chili and casseroles freeze beautifully for up to 3 months. See our freezer meals for busy weeknights for what freezes best.

The pantry hero shopping list

If you stock only a handful of things, make it these. They carry most cheap dinners, and our pantry staples list for budget cooking goes deeper.

Rice and pasta
for the base of almost everything.

Canned beans
for cheap protein and fiber.

Eggs
for breakfast-for-dinner and fried rice.

Frozen vegetables
that never wilt in the crisper.

Canned tomatoes or jarred marinara
for sauces and soups.

Onions and garlic
for flavor on a dime.

Okay, one more detour, and this one is about money.

The Cheap Dinner Vault

Dinner for the whole family. Price tag included.

Stop guessing what dinner costs. The Vault gives you 25 family dinners with the cost per serving worked out, plus everything you need to plan, price and cook a full week on a budget.

Your grocery bill is not a mystery. It is a math problem.

Most "cheap dinner" lists say budget-friendly and never show a number. So you cook,

check out and wince. The Vault flips that. You see the cost first, then decide what is worth making.

Beginners get simple recipes and clear steps. Experienced cooks get the pricing method and stretch tricks that keep costs down week after week.

What you get inside

25 family dinners
Pasta, chicken, ground meat, meatless, egg and soup dinners, each with a cost-per-serving badge.

The pricing method
Price any meal in minutes using the store and month you actually shop.

Cost tracker sheets
Printable pages to record cost, servings and cost per serving for your own favorites.

Picky-eater notes
Simple swaps and tricks on every dinner so the whole table eats.

Stretch-it tricks
Turn one dinner into three with smart leftovers and freezer habits.

Pantry hero list
The six cheap staples that carry most of the menu.

Pick. Price. Cook. Save. Repeat.

Pick three dinners that fit your week.

Price them using the simple method inside.

Cook with easy steps and picky-eater notes.

Save by stretching leftovers into extra meals.

Repeat with your own favorites on the tracker.

Who this is for

Busy parents
You need dinner on the table and the cost under control.

New cooks
You want simple recipes with no special ingredients.

Budget planners
You like numbers and want proof before you spend.

See what dinner really costs.
Get the Vault and plan your next week with the price tag in plain sight.

Get the Cheap Dinner Vault

Instant digital delivery. Works on any phone, tablet or computer.

Seven tired-night tips that actually help

Decide dinner before you’re hungry.
Hungry you makes terrible, expensive choices. Calm you at 10 a.m. is a genius.

Match the recipe to your energy, not your ambition.
Fancy dinner on a Wednesday is how takeout wins.

Buy the shortcut.
Rotisserie chicken, rice pouches and frozen veggies aren’t cheating. They’re staff.

Line the pan with foil.
Future you will be so grateful that you’ll thank past you out loud.

Cook once, eat twice.
Double the slow cooker chicken and tomorrow’s tacos are already done.

Keep a "never again" list.
If a recipe made you cry or cost 14 ingredients, delete it from your life.

Write the plan where everyone can see it.
A fridge list ends "I don’t know, what do you want?" forever.

Plan a whole week of dinners in 10 minutes

Look at your calendar first. Soccer night and late-meeting night get the easiest dinners.

Pick one slow cooker or dump-and-bake night for the busiest day.

Choose two "no-brainer" nights, like quesadillas or breakfast for dinner.

Make a list of what’s missing. Check the pantry before you shop, since it’s tempting to buy a fifth jar of cumin.

Write the plan where everyone can see it. A fridge list ends the "what do you want?" loop.

Want a ready-made version? Our
weekly meal plan for busy families
lays out seven nights with a shopping list.

The picky-eater peace treaty

Serve it deconstructed.
Tacos, baked potatoes and pasta bars let everyone build their own plate.

Keep one safe food on the table.
Bread, rice or fruit means no one leaves hungry.

Offer, don’t push.

Put new foods out with no pressure. It can take many tries before a kid accepts something.

Let them help.
Kids eat more of what they stirred, sprinkled or named.

More strategies in our
picky-eater dinner ideas
.

Find the hidden golden forks

Three golden forks are hiding on this page. Tap each one to earn XP, level up from Takeout Menu Hoarder to Legend of 5:47, and unlock bonus tips and a secret recipe.
0 of 3 forks found

Takeout Menu Hoarder

Level 1 0 XP

Day 1

Hint: one fork is in the intro, one is tucked into a recipe tip, and one is hiding with the leftovers. Play the games, read on and come back tomorrow for a streak bonus. Progress saves on this device.

Play along (yes, it’s for dinner)

Which dinner personality are you?

Dinner bingo

Tap a square when it happens this week. Get three in a row for a bonus.

Last quiet suggestion before we get back to the good stuff.

Put the answer on the fridge

If the hardest part of dinner is asking and answering "what do you want?" every single night, the Rescue Kit’s week planner ends it. Plan once, print the fridge sheet and let the house read it.

Tell it how tired you are.

Pick a dinner and see the dish count.

Plan the week with one click.

Shop the auto-built list, sorted by store section.

Eat dinner and wash fewer dishes.

Plan my week with the Rescue Kit

Free tools, plus a leftovers glow-up

The tired-o-meter

How much gas is left in the tank? Tap one for a dinner idea.

Tap a button above.

What does dinner really cost?

Total cost of the ingredients, divided by servings. That’s it. It’s just a math problem.

Total cost ($)

Servings

One chicken, three dinners

Leftovers don’t have to be the same dinner again. Start with one rotisserie chicken or a batch of slow cooker chicken and remix it. More ideas:
leftover chicken recipes
.

Night 1: Chicken plate.
Serve with rice and steamed or microwaved vegetables.

Night 2: Quesadillas or wraps.
Fold shredded chicken, cheese and salsa into tortillas and crisp in a skillet 2 to 3 minutes per side.

Night 3: Quick soup.
Simmer 4 cups broth with frozen vegetables 10 minutes, add the last of the chicken and a handful of noodles or rice, and heat until hot throughout.

Good to know:
Cool leftovers within 2 hours and store in airtight containers for 3 to 4 days. Reheat to 165 F. Full guidance from
USDA FSIS on leftovers and food safety
.

I want more! Unlock the bonus stash

Every bit of XP you earn opens something new. Peek at what’s waiting.

5 more tired-night tips

Chop vegetables right when you unpack groceries. Future you will cook faster.

Always cook extra rice. It’s tomorrow’s fried rice.

Date your freezer bags with a marker so nothing becomes a mystery brick.

Set a 5-minute reset timer after dinner instead of a full cleanup.

Dinner doesn’t have to be pretty. It has to be eaten.

Bonus recipe: pesto pasta with tomatoes

15 min

Serves 4

1 pot and a colander

You’ll need:
12 oz rotini or penne, 1 jar (6 oz) pesto, 1 cup cherry tomatoes (halved), 1/2 cup grated parmesan. Optional: 2 cups shredded rotisserie chicken.

Boil the pasta in salted water per the package. Scoop out 1/2 cup of pasta water, then drain.

Return the pasta to the pot off the heat. Stir in the pesto and a splash of pasta water until creamy.

Fold in the tomatoes, chicken and parmesan and serve.

The 5-ingredient weekly challenge

Pick five pantry or freezer ingredients you already own, like rice, beans, eggs, frozen vegetables and cheese. Build three different dinners from only those five (plus oil, salt and pepper). Bonus points for zero extra grocery trips. Need inspiration? See our 5-ingredient dinners
.

Dropping soon

Mystery dinner #1

A Level 1 dinner

Mystery dinner #2

A Level 2 dinner

Mystery dinner #3

A Level 3 dinner

Revealed when the timer at the top hits zero. Come back to see what’s inside.

The timer hit zero. Here are this week’s new dinners.
Same Levels, fresh ideas.

New Level 1: Cheesy black bean quesadillas

5 min of effort

About 10 min total

Serves 2

Dishes: 1 skillet

You'll need

4 flour tortillas

1 can (15 oz) black beans, drained and rinsed

1 1/2 cups shredded cheese

Salsa for dipping

Here's how

Mash half the beans with a fork and stir in the rest whole.

Spread beans and cheese over half of each tortilla and fold in half.

Cook in a dry skillet over medium heat 2 to 3 minutes per side, until golden and the cheese melts.

Slice into wedges and serve with salsa.

Good to know:
Mashing some of the beans acts like glue and keeps the filling from sliding out.

New Level 2: Sheet-pan chicken fajitas

15 min of effort

About 35 min total

Serves 4

Dishes: 0 (foil-lined pan)

You'll need

1 1/2 lb boneless chicken breast, sliced into strips

3 bell peppers, sliced

1 onion, sliced

2 tbsp oil

1 packet fajita or taco seasoning

Tortillas and toppings for serving

Here's how

Heat the oven to 425 F and line a sheet pan with foil.

Toss the chicken, peppers and onion with the oil and seasoning right on the pan.

Roast 20 to 25 minutes, stirring once, until the chicken reaches 165 F and the vegetables have browned edges.

Serve in warm tortillas with your favorite toppings.

Good to know:
Slice the chicken thin so it cooks at the same pace as the vegetables.

New Level 3: Slow cooker chicken noodle soup

10 min of effort

6 to 8 hours, hands off

Serves 6

Dishes: 1 (0 with a liner)

You'll need

1 1/2 lb boneless chicken breasts or thighs

6 cups chicken broth

3 carrots and 3 celery stalks, chopped

1 onion, chopped

1 tsp garlic powder, plus salt and pepper

2 cups egg noodles

Here's how

Add the chicken, vegetables, broth and seasonings to the slow cooker.

Cover and cook on LOW 6 to 8 hours, or HIGH 3 to 4 hours, until the chicken reaches 165 F.

Shred the chicken with two forks and return it to the pot.

Stir in the noodles, cover and cook on HIGH 15 to 20 minutes, until tender.

Good to know:
Add the noodles at the end so they don't turn to mush. Leftover soup freezes well without the noodles.

The free recipes stop here, but the fun doesn't.

Decide it. Price it. Done.

Two small tools for two big dinner problems. The Rescue Kit picks tonight's dinner by how tired you are. The Cheap Dinner Vault shows you what it will cost. And since new recipes land every month, there's always something fresh to look forward to.

The Rescue Kit
Dinner picked by energy level, a one-click week plan and an auto grocery list.

Get the Rescue Kit

The Cheap Dinner Vault
25 family dinners with the cost per serving worked out, plus the pricing method.

Get the Vault

Keep reading: more guides to make dinner easier

If this page helped, these pair well with it. Each one goes deeper on a part of tired-night cooking.

Easy Dinner Ideas for When You Have No Energy

Low-effort meals sorted by how worn out you are.

20 Lazy Dinners for When Your Brain Has Left the Building

Twenty recipes sorted by energy level, each with dish counts and step-by-step instructions.

22 Cozy Fall Dinners That Taste Like Wearing Your Favorite Sweater

Find a dinner that matches your energy level tonight.

Easy Sheet-Pan Dinners

One pan, minimal cleanup, big flavor.

Slow Cooker Dinners for Busy Families

Dump it in at noon and eat at six.

Cheap Family Dinners With Cost Per Serving

See the price before you cook.

Weekly Meal Plan for Busy Families

Seven dinners, one shopping list.

Picky-Eater Dinner Ideas

Meals the whole table will actually eat.

Pantry Staples List for Budget Cooking

The few items that carry most dinners.

Freezer Meals for Busy Weeknights

Cook once now, rest easy later.

Leftover Chicken Recipes

Turn one bird into three dinners.

5-Ingredient Dinners

Short grocery list, real dinner.

Sources and further reading:
USDA safe minimum cooking temperatures

USDA MyPlate budget tips

USDA FSIS leftovers guidance

Questions, answered

How do I get access to the Rescue Kit?

Right after checkout. It opens in your web browser, so there’s nothing to install.

Will it save my favorites and meal plans?

Yes, in the browser you use, on the same device. Clearing your browser data will erase them, and they don’t sync between devices.

How do I get the Cheap Dinner Vault?

It’s instant digital delivery, and it works on any phone, tablet or computer.

Do I need special ingredients?

No. The Vault uses everyday groceries and simple recipes.

Are the prices fixed?

Prices change by store and month, so the Vault teaches you the pricing method. You can price any meal with the numbers from the store you actually shop.

What is the easiest weeknight dinner on this page?

The microwave sweet potato with black beans. It takes about 10 minutes, uses one plate and needs almost no cooking skill.

Can I freeze these recipes?

The slow cooker salsa chicken freezes well for up to 3 months. Cool it first, store it in airtight containers and reheat to 165 F. The sheet-pan dinner is best fresh, and the fried rice is best eaten within a day or two.

How do I make dinner cheaper without eating boring food?

Work out the cost per serving, stretch meat with beans or eggs, and build meals around pantry staples. The free calculator in the tools section does the math, and the Cheap Dinner Vault has 25 priced dinners.

How do I get a picky eater to try new foods?

Serve meals deconstructed, keep one safe food on the table and offer new foods without pressure. Letting kids help cook also helps. See the picky-eater peace treaty.

How often do new recipes drop?

The timer at the top counts down to the next recipe update. When it hits zero, the mystery dinners in the bonus section are revealed.

Tonight can be the easy one.

Grab the Rescue Kit for lazy dinners, the Vault for the price tag, or take the free recipes and run. We’re just glad you’re here.

Get the Rescue Kit

Get the Cheap Dinner Vault

Get the Rescue Kit

Make tomorrow's dinner even easier.

Your free resource is yours to keep. If you'd like more help, these optional tools make real-life meal planning easier.

DINNER PLANNING MADE SIMPLE

The 5:47 P.M. Rescue Kit

Find low-effort dinners based on how much energy you have, plus useful planning tools for busy evenings.

EXPLORE THE RESCUE KIT

SHOP SMARTER FOR FAMILY MEALS

The Cheap Dinner Vault

Compare low-cost dinner ideas and practical meal-budget approaches to get more from your groceries.

EXPLORE BUDGET DINNERS

Both resources are optional. Your free printable does not require a purchase.